

Incident Response Tabletop Exercise

Facilitator packet, participant cards, and scenario handouts

Purpose

Use this short guided simulation to practice escalation, communication, role clarity, and decision-making during a cybersecurity incident.



TOTAL TIME

about 2 hours

GROUP SIZE

up to 30

FORMAT

2 activities

Facilitator Overview

This packet runs a short tabletop exercise that lets participants practice what they would do during a cybersecurity incident. The emphasis is not perfection; it is preparation, coordination, and identifying gaps before a real crisis occurs.

Time	Participants	Audience
Approximately 2 hours	Up to 30 learners	Students, staff, or employees who may support incident response decisions

Learning Goals

- Explain why an incident response plan matters before an emergency happens.
- Recognize common response roles and how they coordinate during an incident.
- Practice fast, realistic decision-making when new information changes the situation.

Role	Responsibility in the exercise
Facilitator	Keeps the exercise moving, introduces updates, prompts participation, and keeps the discussion focused.
Participants	Work through the scenario, explain their reasoning, and respond from the role they are assigned.
Evaluator	Notes strengths, weaknesses, and follow-up items for the after-action review.
Observer	Adds subject-matter perspective and asks clarifying questions without taking over the simulation.
Note-taker	Captures decisions, communication gaps, unanswered questions, and suggested improvements.

Materials to Prepare

- Printed rapid response checklist cards
- Role cards and scenario cards
- Timer
- Whiteboard or shared document
- Pens or notepads
- Your organization or course incident response procedure, if available

Activity 1 - Rapid Response Sequencing

30 minutes | individual ranking, small-group discussion, class review

Scenario for participants

A critical server has been encrypted by ransomware. The attacker demands payment in cryptocurrency before they will provide a decryption key. Your job is to decide what should happen first, what can wait, and who needs to be involved.

#	Facilitator steps
1	Hand each participant a checklist card with the response actions in mixed order.
2	Give participants 10 minutes to rank the actions in the order they would take them.
3	Form groups of 3-4. Let groups compare priorities for 10 minutes while each person keeps their own ranking.
4	Use the final 10 minutes to review the response sequence and discuss why timing matters.

Suggested response order

Order	Action
1	Report the incident using the required escalation path.
2	Activate the incident response team.
3	Contain the damage by isolating affected systems.
4	Start an incident timeline and record key facts.
5	Check backup availability and integrity.
6	Use the stakeholder communication plan.
7	Follow notification rules for legal or regulatory requirements.
8	Bring in legal counsel when required.
9	Apply the approved ransom response policy.
10	Contact law enforcement according to policy.

Participant Handout - Rapid Response Checklist Cards

Print, cut, and distribute. Participants number the actions in the order they would take them.

Rapid Response Checklist

- ☐ Isolate affected systems
- ☐ Report the incident through the required escalation process
- ☐ Check the status and integrity of backups
- ☐ Contact law enforcement if policy requires it
- ☐ Bring in legal counsel
- ☐ Follow the organization's ransom response policy
- ☐ Activate stakeholder communications
- ☐ Document the incident timeline
- ☐ Follow legal or regulatory notification procedures
- ☐ Mobilize the incident response team

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Activity 2 - Role-Based Incident Simulation

35-60 minutes | role cards, scenario cards, complication update, group presentations

Purpose

This activity practices cross-functional response. Each group uses assigned roles to make decisions, communicate clearly, and adjust when the situation changes.

#	Simulation flow
1	Give each group one scenario card and assign response roles.
2	Give groups 20 minutes to create an initial response plan.
3	Have each group present its plan in about 5 minutes.
4	Introduce one complication card to each group.
5	Give groups 10 minutes to revise the plan.
6	Ask groups to present how the complication changed their decisions.

Role Cards**IT Security Lead**

Leads containment and technical analysis. Estimates scope, preserves evidence, and coordinates with technical partners.

Incident Commander

Coordinates the response, sets priorities, briefs leadership, and makes time-sensitive decisions.

Communications Lead

Manages internal and external messages, prepares notices, and monitors public or social media updates.

Legal Counsel

Advises on legal exposure, breach notification duties, evidence handling, and communications that create risk.

HR Representative

Manages employee communication, insider-risk questions, workforce continuity, and employee support issues.

Department Manager

Represents impacted operations, reports business impact, and supports continuity decisions.

Scenario and Complication Cards

Use one scenario first. Add one complication after the group presents an initial plan.

Scenario Cards**Ransomware + Data Theft**

File servers are encrypted, and the attacker claims customer financial records were copied. They threaten public release within 24 hours. New concern: backup systems may have been tampered with two weeks ago.

Business Email Compromise

A finance mailbox was taken over and used to authorize a large wire transfer. Similar payment-change requests may have been sent to important clients.

Insider Data Theft

A departing IT employee is stopped while copying customer records to a personal USB drive. The employee says the files are personal, but public posts suggest they may be taking valuable information.

Supply Chain Compromise

A software vendor reports that its update service was compromised. Your systems installed the vendor update yesterday, but the vendor is not yet sharing technical details.

Physical Security Breach

An unauthorized person is found in the server room after hours with a laptop connected to the network. Multiple employees later report unusual badge activity.

Cloud Service Compromise

A cloud provider reports unauthorized access to a repository with customer information and trade secrets. The first message from the provider gives conflicting details about timing and scope.

Complication Cards**Media Leak**

A technology blog publishes incident details that your organization has not confirmed publicly.

Regulator Request

A regulator requests immediate information about the incident and your response steps.

Client Escalation

Your largest client calls an emergency meeting and threatens to end the contract.

Internal Rumors

Employees are discussing the incident internally, and some of the details being shared are wrong.

System Outage

A critical business system goes offline during containment efforts.

Legal Demand

A law firm representing affected customers requests details about the breach and your security controls.

Debrief and After-Action Review

Use these prompts to turn the exercise into specific improvements. Capture gaps, owners, and due dates before participants leave.

Discussion Questions

- How did the sequencing activity help with the role simulation?
- Where did the team hesitate or disagree?
- Which escalation paths, contact lists, or decision authorities were unclear?
- How effective was communication across roles or departments?
- What training, templates, or quick-reference tools would make the next response faster?

Finding	Example from the exercise	Owner	Due date
Unclear escalation path			
Outdated contact list			
Missing notification template			
Unclear decision authority			
Needed training or practice			

Recommended Next Steps

- Update the incident response plan based on gaps found during the exercise.
- Refresh contact lists, escalation paths, and communication protocols.
- Clarify roles, decision authority, and who can approve high-risk actions.
- Schedule regular tabletop exercises using realistic scenarios and different teams.

Quick takeaway: Incident response improves when people know their roles, communicate early, document facts, and practice before pressure is real.